

SK Telecom (017670.KS): Established SK Hyper as AIDC development vehicle

What happened

- On Jul. 23, SKT disclosed that its board approved the establishment of SK Hyper, a wholly owned AI data-center development subsidiary, with an equity commitment of up to W750bn through 2030 ([link](#)). SKT plans to inject an initial W330bn by end-July, with the remaining W420bn to be deployed in stages depending on project progress. SK Hyper will sit between SKT and individual project companies. Separate project-level SPVs are expected to be established for each AIDC, with SKT seeking financial investor (FI) capital at the SPV level rather than funding the entire build-out directly. The announcement follows SKT's Jun. 29 disclosure outlining a first-phase 5GW rollout from 2029 and a longer-term ambition to expand capacity to 15GW by 2035.
- According to local media ([link](#)), SK Hyper will oversee early-stage development activities including site acquisition, power-grid access, permitting, substation development, customer acquisition and commercialization, supporting SKT's previously announced plan to open 5GW of AIDC capacity in phases from 2029. The initial funding will mainly support development of the first c.2GW pipeline, centered on c.1GW projects in Ulsan and the western Chungcheong region. SKT also plans GW-scale infrastructure in the southwestern region.

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GS view

- **Financing structure provides greater clarity, but does not eliminate funding risk:** Based on the announcement, the W750bn commitment appears to fund the AIDC development platform rather than represent the full construction cost of the previously announced 5GW strategy. While SKT intends to ring-fence individual projects into SPVs and attract project-level FI capital, no specific investors, financing terms or equity-sharing arrangements have yet been disclosed.
- **Capital is being committed ahead of tenant and financing visibility:** The initial W330bn injection will primarily fund land, power access, permitting and substation infrastructure for the initial c.2GW pipeline. Although these investments may improve project readiness, they will be deployed before final tenant commitments and project-level financing are secured, creating a risk of extended development periods, lower asset utilization or additional funding

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requirements if customer conversion is slower than expected.

- **The subsidiary structure improves organizational clarity, but does not address project economics:** Establishing a centralized development company may facilitate project execution across regions, but the announcement provides limited incremental detail on expected utilization, pricing, returns on invested capital or the allocation of construction and operating risks among SKT, tenants and external investors. We therefore do not yet assign material value to the broader 5GW pipeline.
- **Limited near-term earnings contribution, with potential pressure on cash flow:** In our view, meaningful operating contribution remains dependent on anchor-tenant contracts, FI participation, construction completion and phased openings from 2029. In the interim, SKT will incur development spending without corresponding revenue, which could weigh on free cash flow and constrain capital-allocation flexibility, including shareholder returns, if funding requirements increase.
- **Overall, we view the announcement as neutral and largely consistent with the existing strategy:** The new structure clarifies how SKT intends to pursue its AIDC ambitions, but does not materially de-risk execution or improve visibility on financial returns at this stage. We believe evidence of contracted demand and acceptable project-level returns is required before the AIDC strategy can support a higher valuation.
- **Key items to monitor include:** 1) binding hyperscaler or anchor-tenant commitments, 2) confirmed FI participation and financing terms, 3) SKT's ultimate equity contribution and guarantees at each SPV, 4) expected utilization and project-level returns, and 5) whether the W750bn remains the upper limit of SKT's exposure.

Price Target Risks and Methodology - SK Telecom

Valuation methodology: We are Sell rated on SKT. Our P/E-based 12m TP is W58,000. Our target P/E multiple of 9x (applied to NTM) is derived from SKT's historical NTM P/E, which has been consistently trading around 9x throughout the 5G era.

Key upside risks: Key upside risks include 1) sharper recovery in SKT's market share from new subscribers and mobile number portability; 2) reinstatement of dividends to level prior to data breach; 3) clarity on monetization trajectory of strategic divestments.

017670.KS	12m Price Target: W58,000	Price: W99,500	Downside: 41.7%
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Sell	GS Forecast				
Market cap: W21.6tr / \$14.6bn Enterprise value: W28.6tr / \$19.3bn 3m ADTV: W147.7bn / \$97.8mn South Korea Korea TMT & Consumer M&A Rank: 3 Leases incl. in net debt & EV?: Yes		12/25	12/26E	12/27E	12/28E
	Revenue (W bn)	17,099.3	17,705.0	18,009.1	18,195.2
	EBITDA (W bn)	4,663.4	5,464.9	5,597.4	5,600.0
	EPS (W)	1,918	6,219	6,692	6,701
	P/E (X)	28.6	16.0	14.9	14.8
	P/B (X)	0.9	1.7	1.6	1.5
	Dividend yield (%)	3.0	3.6	3.6	3.6
	N debt/EBITDA (ex lease,X)	1.5	1.2	1.1	1.0
	CROCI (%)	28.4	27.4	28.2	27.9
	FCF yield (%)	10.6	10.0	10.3	10.4
		3/26	6/26E	9/26E	12/26E
	EPS (W)	1,514	1,534	1,381	1,790

Source: Company data, Goldman Sachs Research estimates, FactSet. Price as of 23 Jul 2026 close.

Disclosure Appendix

Reg AC

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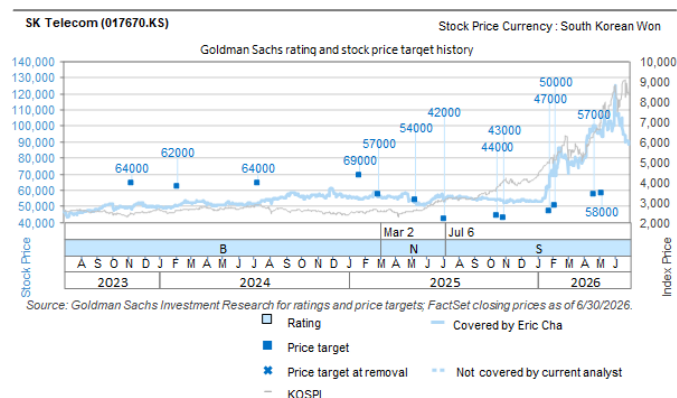
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SK Telecom (017670.KS)

Date of report	Target price (W)	Closing price (W)
07-May-26	58,000	93,200
22-Apr-26	57,000	100,300
07-Feb-26	50,000	69,200
26-Jan-26	47,000	61,800
30-Oct-25	43,000	52,700
16-Oct-25	44,000	54,800
06-Jul-25	42,000	54,400
12-May-25	54,000	52,200
02-Mar-25	57,000	56,000
23-Jan-25	69,000	54,900
11-Jul-24	64,000	52,300
05-Feb-24	62,000	50,400
08-Nov-23	64,000	48,400

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